Muchhu Chaudhuri as Chief of Army Staff while holding back his elevation to a four-star rank.

Chaudhuri had taken the initiative to appoint Lieutenant General Henderson Brooks and Brigadier Prem Bhagat to make an independent analysis of the war. Chaudhuri's initial brief to Brooks and Bhagat was all-encompassing in its scope, but the chief had to back down quickly when it was pointed out to him by the DMO, Brigadier D. K. Palit, that this would allow the two officers to access all the files pertaining to governmental policy decisions. Obviously, if the Henderson Brooks-Bhagat Report was to have teeth, its level would have to be raised beyond Army HQ. When the matter was taken up with the new defence minister, Y. B. Chavan, the government let it be known that 'it did not wish to institute an enquiry into high-level policies and decisions'. So instead of the committee being upgraded to widen its scope, it remained as it had been originally constituted, while its terms of reference were changed. The two officers were ordered to confine themselves to analysing IV Corps' operations only.

Chavan then indulged in some sleight of hand, so common in democracies where those in power need to cover their own follies. Once completed, the report was locked up and few individuals outside the Cabinet were granted access to it. In a subsequent low-key statement in Parliament, Chavan ascribed the debacle in NEFA entirely to the 'failure of military commanders and to the tactical mishandling of troops on the ground'. The defence minister thereby succeeded not only in diverting any criticism from Nehru's government, he also created the impression that the Henderson Brooks-Bhagat Report was a definitive review of the entire Sino-Indian conflict, which was certainly not the case.

Though most of the report's content is known, there continues to be an aura of mystery around it as some critical parts have not yet been 'leaked'. However, those who have been privy to it are emphatic that there is nothing that is not known. It continues to remain under wraps only because despite their brief, the two officers hint at the skewed decision-making system that existed then.

By the end of the 1950s the civil-military equation had become so warped that a man of General Thimayya's stature could be reduced to a virtual non-entity. Success and survival in the military hierarchy depended on falling in line with the 'Chosen One' or at best by keeping one's mouth shut and sailing with the wind, as was the case with General Pran Thapar